The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Iran's president rejected Donald Trump's demand for Iran's "unconditional surrender". On Saturday Masoud Pezeshkian apologised to neighbouring **Gulf states** attacked by his country since the war with America and Israel began. He later added that Iran was targeting only American military facilities in the region. The Iranian Revolutionary Guard Corps said it had launched an attack on the American base in Juffair, Bahrain.

Despite Mr Pezeshkian's words, **Iran** continued to fire missiles and drones across the Gulf. A tower in Kuwait was set ablaze, although the cause of the fire was not confirmed. In Bahrain a university was damaged. The country's foreign ministry bemoaned indiscriminate "Iranian aggression" and said a water desalination plant had also been hit by a drone. Earlier, the president of the United Arab Emirates said his country was in a "time of war".

Mr Trump said he was considering targeting new "areas and groups of people" for "complete destruction and certain death". Some 1,172 civilians have been killed in strikes on Iran, according to Human Rights Activists News Agency, an American group. Reports suggested that the skies above Tehran had turned black after oil facilities were struck.

Mr Trump accused **Britain** of trying to join the war "after we've already won". America's president said that Britain—"our once great ally"—was considering sending two aircraft-carriers to the Middle East. "That's OK, Prime Minister Starmer, we don't need them any longer—but we will remember," he posted. Britain originally refused America's request to use its bases for attacks on Iran, before relenting a little.

China's foreign minister said **America's** war with **Iran** "should not have happened" and called for its "immediate" end. But Wang Yi suggested China still sought to arrange a meeting between Mr Trump and China's leader, Xi Jinping; he noted that failure to maintain dialogue between the countries would lead to "misunderstandings and misjudgments". The summit is expected to take place at the end of March.

Balendra Shah looked set to become **Nepal's** prime minister after preliminary results showed his Rastriya Swatantra Party claimed a big election victory. Mr Shah unseated the previous PM, Sharma KP Oli, having stood against him in his parliamentary constituency. In September a student-led revolution forced Mr Oli to stand down. Mr Shah's RSP attracted young voters unhappy with establishment parties.

One of **OpenAI's** top researchers resigned following the firm's controversial deal with the Pentagon. Caitlin Kalinowski, who heads OpenAI's robotics team, cited her fears that, under the agreement, artificial intelligence would be used to develop autonomous weapons and prompt the "surveillance of Americans without judicial oversight". OpenAI insists it has provisions in place to mitigate such use. Anthropic, a rival, walked away from a similar deal.

Word of the week: *hujjat al-islam*, an Islamic title equivalent to a middle-ranking Christian priest. Read our obituary of Ali Khamenei.

Photograph: Marijan Murat/dpa

A fear-fuelled election in Germany's car hub

An election in Baden-Württemberg on Sunday kicks off Germany's *Superwahljahr*, a "super election year" in which five of the country's 16 states go to the polls. The centre-right Christian Democrats (CDU) hope to unseat the Greens, who have run the south-western state, one of Germany's largest, for 15 years. But the CDU's polling lead has evaporated in recent weeks. Cem Özdemir, the Green candidate and the son of Turkish guest workers, could become Germany's first-ever state premier with an immigrant background. A loss for the CDU would be a disaster for Friedrich Merz, Germany's conservative chancellor.

Economic anxiety has shaped the campaign in one of Europe's richest regions. Home to Mercedes, Porsche and countless car suppliers, Baden-Württemberg built its prosperity around a technology—the internal combustion engine—facing obsolescence. Lay-offs have inspired (exaggerated) fears that Stuttgart, the state capital, could become a second Detroit. Aiming to capitalise on the angst, the hard-right Alternative for Germany may achieve its best-ever result in a western German state.

Photograph: Shutterstock

Colombia’s centrists eye a comeback

Colombians vote in legislative elections on Sunday. The race for Congress has already been marred by violence and allegations of vote-buying. To maintain order, authorities have banned alcohol sales from Saturday night.

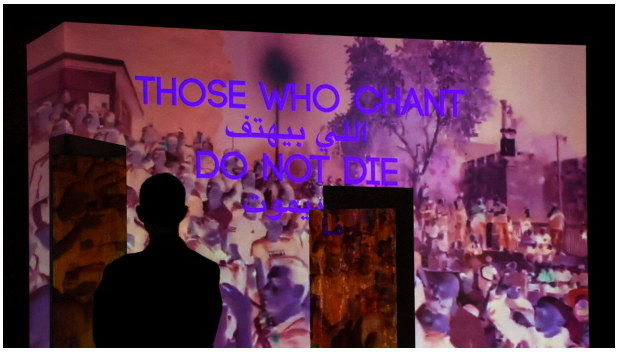
People will also vote in three presidential primaries. Sixteen candidates feature, split into coalitions representing the left, centre and right. The winner could lead their party into the first round of the election in May, but not before negotiating with the three most popular candidates, who are not on Sunday’s ballot. (The constitution prevents the left-wing incumbent, Gustavo Petro, from re-election.) They are Iván Cepeda, a left-wing senator barred from running on technical grounds; Sergio Fajardo, a centrist former mayor of Medellín, who is running independently; and Abelardo de la Espriella, a polemical criminal lawyer and political outsider. Many are watching Claudia López, a centrist ex-mayor of Bogotá, the capital, who has risen in polls. Her showing may indicate whether centrism can stage a comeback in a polarised country.

Photograph: Getty Images

All change in F1

An element of mystery surrounds the first race of a Formula One season. After a winter of testing, fans and pundits are never quite sure how the cars will run. But there *was* even less certainty than usual ahead of the 2026 season, which began on Sunday in Melbourne, and not just because of the travel disruption caused by the war in the Middle East.

The sport’s governing body enforced a host of new rules, which include making the cars shorter, narrower and lighter. It is also insisting on hybrid engines powered by electricity as well as internal combustion. Meanwhile, two new carmaking giants entered the fray. Audi, owned by Volkswagen, has taken over the Sauber team, and Cadillac is joining the grid in a new venture part operated by General Motors. For now, neither is likely to challenge for the podium. George Russell of Mercedes won in Melbourne, ahead of his teammate, Kimi Antonelli.



Photograph: Reuters

A contemplative Whitney Biennial

For decades the Biennial at the Whitney Museum of American Art in New York has surveyed the state of the country's art. The exhibition that opens this weekend falls in America's bisesquicentennial (250th) year, already one of turmoil.

The works on show explore themes such as technology, conflict and climate change. The experience is immersive. In "Pandemonium", a digital projection by Michelle Lopez, newspaper clippings, the American flag and debris whirl across the ceiling while violins screech. An oil painting by Ali Eyal portrays an amusement park in Baghdad, the city of his birth, which he left shortly before the Iraq war in 2003. Oswaldo Maciá uses scent and sound to celebrate extinct insects. The museum says the exhibition is a display of "togetherness through difference". It asks visitors to consider what makes art "American"—and offers no simple answers.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

They all gave the correct answers of:

Skyler Hutto, Orangeburg, South Carolina, America
Hélène Tremblay, Gatineau, Canada
Vince Sinclair, Godalming, Britain

The questions were: Daily Express, The Signal and the Noise, conductors, platform shoes and a track. The theme is railways (railroads) which have express trains, signals, conductors, platforms and tracks

Monday: Which British newspaper, when owned by Lord Beaverbrook, had the largest circulation in the world in the 1940s?
Tuesday: Which book by Nate Silver, published in 2012, is about the art of interpreting statistics?
Wednesday: Arturo Toscanini, Leopold Stokowski and Claudio Abbado all achieved fame in what role?
Thursday: What type of footwear, which raised the user's height, was very popular in the 1970s?
Friday: What musical term refers to both an individual song on an album and an isolated channel from a single instrument that is mixed with others to make a recording?

The great nations have always acted like gangsters, and the small nations like prostitutes.

Stanley Kubrick